

I've ever met."

Mensik spent another five days training with Djokovic in Montenegro, and the knowledge he gleaned from both sessions helped propel him to four titles on the Future Circuit in 2022.

The following year, in his men's Grand Slam debut at the US Open, he qualified and surged to the third round where No. 9 seed Taylor Fritz outclassed him 6-1, 6-2, 6-0.

Achieving a critical Davis Cup victory over Serbia's No. 52 Dusan Lajovic last September, and reaching a Challenger final in Canberra, Australia, this January, further boosted his confidence going into

Giant killer: Mensik outlasted former world No. 1 Andy Murray 7-6 (6), 6-7 (3), 7-6 (4) to reach his first ATP Tour quarterfinal. GETTY IMAGES

the Australian Open.

There the 6'4" Mensik again qualified and then upset former No. 10 Denis Shapovalov, a lefty shot-maker, in straight sets in the opening round.

Sometimes an impressive loss can prove as meaningful as a big win. That's exactly what happened when Mensik extended world No. 9 Hubert Hurkacz to 6-7(9), 6-1, 5-7, 6-1, 6-3 in the second round.

"The match with Hurkacz is something that I compared with the match against Fritz," he told *ATP.com*.

"Last year, I played Fritz in the third round, and he just beat me out of the court. Four months later, I played against the same kind of level of player and now it was five sets. I just can see the improvement.... I now have the confidence that I can play with these big guys and that I can really beat the big guys."

Mensik backed up those words soon enough. At the recent Qatar ExxonMobil Open in Doha, he whipped No. 24 Alejandro Davidovich Fokina 7-6 (3), 6-4 for his first win over a top 30 opponent.

He then outlasted former world No. 1 Andy Murray 7-6 (6), 6-7 (3), 7-6 (4) to reach his first ATP Tour quarterfinal.

Afterwards, he celebrated with a Djokovic-like primal roar. Heavily favoured Andrey Rublev became the Czech's next big-name victim, going down 6-4, 7-6 (6). That made Mensik the youngest player to defeat a Top-5 player since Carlos Alcaraz knocked out Stefanos Tsitsipas at the 2021 U.S. Open.

Nicknamed 'Menimal' — shorthand for his ferocious, animal-like power — the brawny Mensik will beat many more 'big guys' this year and for years to come.

